



How to Write

The Perfect Personal Statement 2021

I distinctly remember the many pairs of twitching eyebrows, tapping fingers, and the exaggerated signs of my classmates while we had a discussion about the use of nuclear energy in Japan. Although we intended to be a debate, whenever someone they were immediately interrupted by someone who disagreed with them. We failed to see the value of learning from facts, and by the end of the day, we were frustrated by our inability to reach a conclusion.



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**Students' names have been changed at their request*



Expert tips for writing your university application essay

Learn what's most important when it comes to writing stellar application essays for US and UK universities!

The essay plays an enormous role in successful applications to the world's best universities. Whether you're applying to US colleges using the Common Application or UK universities through UCAS, there are several key components admissions officers look for in top applicants. While the Common App essay is generally more reflective, creative and personal, the UCAS personal statement is more academically oriented and course-specific.

To help you understand more about what goes into a successful US or UK application essay, we've gathered some top tips from our very own admissions experts.

Tips for US Applicants

According to Gabe Gladstein, a Harvard graduate and Crimson senior Strategist, your US Common App essay should demonstrate personal growth and the insights you've gained through your reflections on a formative experience. Here are his top 5 tips for students applying to universities in the US.

01.

It can be difficult and mysterious trying to navigate writing your Common App essay. A great way to approach it is to rely on a trusted format that's worked for thousands of students whose essays we've read and supported. The best Common App essays often follow what I call the "Three Step Experience" format. First you write about an experience from your life that is meaningful to you; then you talk about what you learned from that experience; and finally, you talk about why what you learned matters to you, connecting it to who you are now and who you aspire to be in the future.

02.

Your passions can definitely work as a starting point for an essay topic. But you need to be careful to focus not on the passion itself so much as how the passion has impacted you and your view of the world. How your perspectives on your passion have grown and changed over time are what matters, rather than the passion itself.

03.

Admissions officers care more about the insights you have than they do about the event that you're writing about in your essay. You can talk about a really significant event in your life, but if you haven't learned much about yourself or the world from that event, then AOs won't care. You don't need to tell a sad or traumatic story — and in fact, trying to lean on sympathy doesn't work with Admissions Officers. They want to see personal growth, and that can come from even the most seemingly insignificant experiences.

04.

So — how do you capture your insights in an essay? Try using a few key questions to dig up the insights from your experiences. First, in what way(s) are you a better person now, after your experience, than you were before? What changed, and why? Second, How did your misjudgments and miscalculations — the mistakes you made — along the way lead you to learn more about yourself, and exactly what did you learn? Once you've answered those questions, work to integrate those answers particularly into the last two paragraphs to flesh out your final reflections on your experience, and to connect them to how they've made you a better person today, and a solid applicant. The key to a great Common App essay is focusing on the reflection, and making that reflection (and the self-improvement inherent in the reflection) feel genuine rather than forced.

05.

Finally — in your conclusion, try to avoid language that suggests you've learned all there is to know about something, or you've become an expert on something (including yourself!). There will always be more to learn as a 17/18/19 year old, so you don't want to indicate arrogance to your AOs. Instead, emphasize the ongoing struggle to be the best version of you, and how your work to be a better person, learner, and listener is only just beginning. This will help you to come across as mature and full of perspective.





Tips for UK Applicants

When writing your UCAS personal statement there are a few key phrases to keep in mind throughout the process, according to Abbi Colwyn, an Oxford and LSE graduate and lead UK Strategist. She says, "Show, don't tell. Discuss, don't list. Be unique, not a carbon copy of what you think universities want to see." Here are her top 5 tips for students applying to universities in the UK.

01.

Rewrite, refine, redraft: writing the personal statement is a process of rewriting. Try not to be sentimental over everything you write in your first or second draft; be open to revising and reworking some of the content and structure to make it more concise, well-conceived, and insightful.

02.

Carefully consider where to prioritise your character count: because the statement is only 4000 characters (47 lines), you have to be selective about which extracurricular activities and books you include and which to devote the most characters to. To help with this, think about where your most profound and interesting reflections come from and which activities best help you explore and demonstrate these. Also think about what makes you stand out. For example, a lot of students engage in debating, competitions, and participate in clubs at school; not all students have set up their own NGO, or worked with a professor on a research project which is getting published.

03.

Deepen your insight: rather than merely paraphrasing what you have read or giving a surface level description of what you have done, evaluate what you have learned from these experiences and how this links

to broader insights relevant to your major. For example, an average student will just tell universities "I achieved an honorable mention in a politics essay competition", a better student will tell unis what they wrote about, what they concluded, what inspired them to discuss this topic, what challenges they faced in research and how they overcame this, whether they would change their ideas with hindsight, and how they built on this essay through further exploration.



04.

Draw interesting and unique connections. Once you have collated the relevant wider reading and extracurriculars you have done, really take the time to think through how these build on one another and how one inspired the next. Universities want to see how you think. They want to know you are both curious and proactive/committed to start to find the answers to your questions for yourself.

05.

Make sure every paragraph has a purpose: when structuring your personal statement, every paragraph should add something new — whether it's demonstrating a separate interest/concept relevant to your major or a different approach (practical vs theoretical). Make sure this purpose is clearly communicated in the opening sentence of the paragraph; this needs to frame the paragraph (so we know what it will be about) but also excite the admissions officer and make them want to read more.

Now that you know what makes a successful application essay truly stand out to admissions officers, it's time to see how this advice is put into action! The following 23 essays were written by students who worked with their Crimson essay mentors to put their passions, perspectives and personalities on paper — from brainstorming and outlining to drafting and editing (and editing again). These are the final essays our students submitted to gain admission to countless world-leading universities in the US and UK. We hope you'll find them helpful and inspiring!





“Why does your mom have eight arms, Ayaka?” my classmate, Ryan, asked curiously, glancing at my artwork.

Before I could answer that it was because she always multi-tasked as if she really had eight arms, he called Mrs. Hatcher over, who immediately complimented Ryan’s red-fish-blue-fish painting before pausing in confusion at my portrait.

“Maybe you should try again, Ayaka.”

Since kindergarten, ridicule has been the typical response to my art. My one-legged elephant, my musical about a lonely moon, my story about a monkey raised by werewolves. Nobody got it. I was the only one who loved these bizarre ideas, and I felt isolated. Without anyone to appreciate them, I started keeping my creativity to myself. In time, this translated into striving to fit everybody’s expectations. I started to draw my mom with two arms.

But I still held on to one indulgence of my true spirit: poetry. I loved all poetry, from Dr. Seuss’s quirky words and ideas that bounced off pages like songs, to haikus that layered inner emotions with nature’s beauty in just seventeen syllables. Composing poetry allowed me to capture my raw emotions, those sometimes squiggly hard-to-define feelings, and express them in ways no other art form allowed. But fear of judgment kept my creations hidden from the world.

In my junior year, I first read William Carlos Williams’s “The Red Wheelbarrow.” Some classmates found significance in the color red, and others found meaning in the white. But I was fascinated by its structure: four short simple stanzas. The unconventional structure welcomed me into a world where structure didn’t demand conformity. The poem assured me that being unconventional had value.

Inspired, I decided to create an original poem. Word after word flooded onto my paper—reflections on how stifled I was being forced to follow social norms, how I lost confidence in expressing who I was, how I hid feelings and thoughts from myself and others. But as words unfolded, I had peeled off the outer layers of the Ayaka-cabbage, revealing my core.

When I finally completed my poem, I slumped back in my chair, and read it. Again, and again, and again. Then I waited. One day, two days. Two weeks, Three weeks.

The words—my voice—slowly simmered within me. This poem couldn't just sleep in my notebook. That would mean I would once again hide who I am. My poem woke up, walked off the page, and took me to the website of the Japan Poets Club Poetry Contest. But the idea of being dismissed, just like in kindergarten, left my cursor hovering over the submit button. After a minute, I knew it was time to seek value in my work regardless of what others think; I was ready to embrace the fact I had eight arms.

Click.

Congratulations, your poetry has been successfully submitted.

Until then, I was never able to Dr. Seuss my own fanciful animals. I couldn't red-wheelbarrow my white chickens. The eyes and words of others caged my inner self. But finally, I realized the importance of embracing the whole width of A Y A K A.

Today, I treat my life as if it is its own poetry. Creating palindromes, having a collection of cacti, vlogging about my everyday life, and that's just the beginning of my list.

My mom does have two arms. But from time to time I draw her with eight arms. Other days five. Why? Because...

"You shouldn't draw outside the lines"

"Your painting is confusing"

The lines are so restricting

"You're petite"

"You're too tall"

The lines are so restricting

"You should smile more"

"You should sit like a woman"

The lines are so restricting

"You are such a nerd"

"You are so weird"

The lines are so restricting

Then one day, I drew outside the lines

Because the lines were so restricting.



The only sound my 13-year-old self could hear was that of powerful water droplets in the sink and the silver dishcloths rubbing the plates in that loathsome prison that was our kitchen.

The insufferable air in the atmosphere established that neither me nor Carolina, Melissa, and Isabella, my three little sisters, stood the mere presence of one another.

In truthfulness, though, I was only pretending to be an unapproachable and efficient dishwasher obligated to wash the same dishes repeatedly (instead of being able to experience his new video game or Lego set).

I was hiding the fact that my heart ached at the possibility of having ruined what I considered crucial relationships. But one thought wouldn't leave my mind as I drifted away from the endless dishes: the universe had extended its hand towards me with an opportunity for me to reconcile with them.

I needed them to know that I missed the times we played video games, build Legos, and watched Hell's Kitchen. Yes, that was it.

"You know, you're lucky I'm not Gordon Ramsey," I said, halting the monologue of the sink, "or else you'd all be gone by now."

They looked confused.

Yet I knew it was more than that. We had always loved the show.

"Are you going to help or just stand there?" Isabella retaliated.

I chose the first option.

I couldn't hide my eagerness as I explained how I had an idea to implement some changes in the kitchen based on my video games. By modifying some of our responsibilities there, we could escape from that place quicker.

My sisters' silence transformed my excitement into crestfallenness. I thought it was a matter of time before they would start yelling at me about how I repeatedly found a creative way to mess everything up.

Gradually, however, something else occurred.

Even though many of the visits my sisters paid me in my room had the purpose of me helping them with homework, I was now often relieved. It was as if they appeared to feel safer now when approaching me.

Maybe that is what our relationship lacked: an assurance that I cared.

These visits also propelled an unexpected feeling of excitement within me. I realized how rather simple things in my daily life, like a video game or a TV show, could play a role in something bigger than myself, such as a relationship.

I was motivated to replicate the idea of using my hobbies for a significant cause after seeing how it had a small but considerable impact on me and my sisters. Yet, I suppose I rooted my desire to be unapproachable (or shyness) so deep inside me that I had goosebumps at the thought of leaving my comfort zone for these experiences.

Still, I convinced myself to give it a chance, just like I did when I opted to count on my sisters for help in the kitchen.

This attempt, which started with me helping them with their homework, transformed itself into things like working on a scientific project which would help those who don't have access to clean water or collecting costumes for pediatric oncology patients undergoing harsh treatment.

Every time I made a minor difference by merely doing what I liked to do, I realized how I had been hiding so long behind a wall of unapproachability from countless opportunities before my stay in prison.

Now, when my sisters and I embark on our daily journeys to that place or on our occasional adventures to watch Hell's Kitchen, I often think of how something I dreaded allowed us to come together.

It showed me that if I could be more open-minded to even the smallest, meaningless experiences like dishwashing, I could be there for people the same way my sisters wished I were there for them.

And that also didn't mean I couldn't be an efficient and focused dishwasher when required.



“Samuel is a good listener and a motivated learner, but he is often distracted and rolls around on the floor with his friends during group activities.” Such was 5-year-old Sam Clark as described by preschool teacher Ms. Kim—much more interested in somersaults across the carpet than focused academics. I teemed with energy and could find no way of containing it, necessitating incessant fidgeting, a near perpetual stream of talking and singing, and frequent breaks from reading time for classroom gymnastics. To both the amusement and frustration of preschool teachers, I needed and would always find outlets, acceptable or not, to release this erupting energy.

As I have grown older and arguably more mature, my energy has not dissipated, but has rather found forums in which to flourish. My physical energy, once only manifested in squirming and poorly executed classroom cartwheels, has been honed in martial arts. Entering the Tae Kwon Do studio seven years ago, I had no knack for any sport; I was “built for math,” as my instructor Ms. Theresa said—more comfortable with algebra than a well-placed punch. I never expected that I would win tournaments, teach classes, and sport a 3rd degree black belt. But it was that same raw energy, that same joy in illicit preschool somersaulting, that fueled my training, teaching, and success in the martial arts world and continues to do so.

My vigorous verbal energy has inspired, and perhaps necessitated, a fascination with debate. This insatiable drive to speak produced the fierce fervor with which I approach debates—on topics from alternative energy to welfare reform. My discoveries and frustrations over the course of extensive research or a debate round have sparked a deep and continuing interest in domestic and foreign policy; I feel driven now to pursue such interests, and debate has ignited an intense desire to stay informed and engaged as I dissect policy intricacies and an opponent’s case. Debate has rerouted younger Sam’s torrent of random post-somersaulting comments into zealous yet calculated speeches on important issues.

While debate and martial arts allow a release of energy through a rapid rebuttal or a 540° roundhouse kick, theatre provides the ultimate forum. Improvisation and sketch comedy have become arenas in which this energy can explode, virtually unhindered, while individual roles in a variety of productions have focused this energy to create specific mannerisms and fuel powerful motives. As I have transformed myself into a tormented and inebriated fish-man (Caliban) a preaching, dancing showman (the Wiz), or simply, dare I say it, an ass (Bottom and Dogberry), my rolling on the floor with friends has tumbled down different paths. My 5-year-old desire to roll without restraint has evolved into a passion to experience every aspect of theatre—from acting to directing to writing to lighting design—as it is now the theatre, rather than cartwheels, that I truly enjoy.

Through martial arts, debate, and theatre I have been able to mold a rampant energy from a spastic nuisance into true joys that I hope to continue and pursue. But I believe that the most important and rewarding outgrowth of this energy has been my ability to recognize the same trait in kids whom I teach. In teaching martial arts, I believe that the insane energy of kids is something to be embraced rather than stamped out. Many of the kids I teach, in both after-school programs at private schools and classes at transitional housing programs and homeless shelters, suffer frequent reprimands, as I did, for their fervor and glee in their rigorous schools or struggling home lives. A martial arts class should be a release, a place where energy is cultivated and encouraged, and used to build fitness, skill, and confidence—rather than one more setting where enthusiasm is condemned. To me, little is more rewarding and exhilarating than teaching and pushing students to do what they never imagined they could, and I believe that it is the enthusiasm in the students and myself that drives such success.

I take a similar approach elsewhere: whether choreographing and leading a performance with my martial arts school's Demonstration Team, assistant-directing a production at the Jewish Community Center, coaching novice debaters, or hosting an improv show. In all these outlets, I am driven by this raw energy and I believe that it is imperative; the black belts kick harder and jump higher, the improv-ers think faster, the actors perform better, and the debaters hammer home their points.

I no longer roll around on the floor during class. But the brimming energy that drove my preschool acrobatics has not subsided in the least; rather, it has become the driving force behind all that I do. From the debate podium to the classroom to the stage, I try to, and often must, approach everything with this vigor. These endeavors have become my “rolling around on the floor with friends,” my release, and my passion, and I cannot wait to see what more will fill that role as I move forward. I suppose if all else fails, I can go back to somersaults.



“Èkó ò ní bàjé ooooo,” my Grandma said to us in Yoruba at our annual Christmas dinner in Lagos, a bustling city in Nigeria.

I sat there confused about what this phrase meant but continued to speak in my English accent and show off the new vocabulary I had learnt from boarding school in England. As the granddaughter of the event, I thought it would only be polite to introduce myself around.

“Good evening, my name is Faramola Bakare and I am going to be the President of Nigeria,” I proclaimed loudly in my age-eleven voice. An elderly woman said to me, “that’s not how to pronounce your name, young lady, you’re speaking like Western people.” Everyone laughed, but I did not get the joke.

At school in England, I was known as the ‘cool’ Nigerian: the Nigerian who travels the world, attends the hottest concerts and hosts exuberant “owambes” (grandiose parties). I liked this version of me: it was the popular me. When I showed my friends pictures of Lagos, I only showed them the fancy shops and the sandy dunes of its beaches. I deleted the pictures of bad days in Lagos and maintained a perfect image of Lagos in order to counter the narrative of Africa, ‘the heart of darkness’ riddled with poverty. The illusion I had painted of Lagos to my schoolmates was too beautiful to be tainted by the bleaker reality: rubbish lining the streets, children begging on the side of the road, blaring melanges of police officers with AK-47s and nowhere to go. In truth, I was ashamed of Lagos.

Age 16, I was driving back from our family-organised food drive in Elegbata, an impoverished neighbourhood on the outskirts of Lagos, when my mum and I realised that we had a few more relief packages left. We decided to stop and distribute the rest of the packages in the community. In the blink of an eye, an army of men rushed to the car like they were chasing their kidnapped children. Soon after, violence broke out. I could feel the hunger and desperation of the people, a moshpit of anger. The turmoil reflected the disease caused by socio-economic disparity within the community. At that moment, I feared that there was no cure.

I recognized that I was hiding the reality of Lagos from my friends because it was the easier option. I couldn’t say my name because I didn’t know who I was. I realised that I could not help a country I did not identify with, that was the joke.

“Èkó ò ní bàjé” means “Lagos will not spoil”. I am learning to take pride in my country and acknowledge that to help Lagos not spoil, I have to play my part. I now understand that having the privilege of soaking up the sun on the sandy dunes cannot insulate me from Nigeria’s systematic issues.

More than ever, I am determined to understand Lagos' complex nature and champion my Grandma's mantra that Lagos will not spoil. To begin to address Lagos's systematic issues, I lead an outreach supporting single mothers to launch businesses in the Dopemu community. Last year, I created STEM in Africa (SIA), an organisation that raises awareness around careers in STEM for young African students. I believe advocating for STEM in Nigeria will catalyse a new way of thinking for the next generation of Africans. SIA has already impacted two hundred and thirty students' lives through STEM education and we are just getting started. I hope to better understand how to sustainably make an impact in communities.

At the inaugural ceremony of SIA, attended by the students and supporting partners, I stood to say, "Good evening, I am Faramola Bakare. Thank you for believing in the youth of Nigeria, you are leaving the nation in good hands. We have a long way to go, but Èkó ò ní bàjé ooooo."



Kairos

Seated at the top of a hill, overlooking a valley of plantations, sat an old white house, with paint that was ever so slightly starting to chip. We walked up the steep staircase to enter the front door and were greeted with the smell of old wood and books; a smell that I would eventually come to miss. For four nights, my peers and I would live in this house for our Kairos retreat. Kairos is a retreat for juniors and seniors at my school, Loyola Blakefield. During the retreat, my classmates and I were put into small groups of 5-6 and led through a series of exercises to grow our relationships with God.

My meeting room was the last one on the left. The walls were painted green. There was an old chandelier hanging from the ceiling. The room was quiet which allowed thoughts to flow. The room smelled like the outdoor's brisk air. In this old room, the group leaders would ask us to draw and describe a graph of our lives with all the highs and lows of our 17 years. While I was able to write down my life graph, I had a hard time expressing my answers to the questions out loud. My parents got a divorce when I was 9. Life became more about my mother and father's relationship, or lack thereof, rather than caring for my siblings and me. I felt like it wasn't fair to dump this story on my groupmates. I felt like it was my baggage to carry, and not theirs.

I felt horrible that I couldn't express my answers in the small group. I met with the adult leader, who happened to be my guidance counselor, Mr. Lankford. Since I was a freshman, I had met with him every month. During my sophomore year, I went through a difficult time with lacrosse; I wasn't the starter on varsity, and I was having difficulty adjusting to my role as a backup in the sport I loved. When I spoke to him about lacrosse, my jealousy and anger started to fade away. I didn't worry about how my coaches viewed me or how I wasn't getting the playing time I expected. Instead, I focused on myself and what I could do to improve my game. When I told Mr. Lankford I wasn't comfortable telling the group my story because I didn't think any of my group mates could relate to it, he responded by telling me the whole point of the small groups was to open up and be vulnerable. I decided to finally tell Mr. Lankford the story of my parents' divorce, in the hope that my thought process would change the same way it changed how I viewed being a backup my sophomore year. After speaking to Mr. Lankford, I built up enough courage to share the story with my small group the next day.

My story seemed to be unavoidable, and as time started to tick away, I became more and more nervous. I didn't know what to expect after telling my story. I couldn't tell if my parents' divorce was too much for my group mates to handle, and part of me still doubted if telling my story would make me feel differently. After sharing, I was surprised by the love and support of my group mates. I discovered that the divorce didn't define me as a person unless I wanted it to. Kairos was my reset button. It showed me that a problem is only a problem if I perceive it to be. I discovered that I was no longer chained to my past.

"True freedom is understanding that we have a choice in who and what we allow to have power over us."

— Meryl Streep



Welcome to y(our) home

The first time I heard “Welcome, make yourself at home” was when I went to live in the SOS Children’s Village, a Brazilian orphanage. Auntie Goreth, a social mother, was waiting in front of the house with other residents. There, I grew up amongst different stories, setbacks, and dreams. The Village’s sense of community made me feel embraced and safe, especially when we sat around the large wooden table for lunch, to do our homework or to share experiences. Auntie Goreth received me willing to know me, and I harbored the illusion that I would always be welcomed.

All of that changed when Auntie Goreth died and I went to live with my first foster family. The first foster home was a “traditional Brazilian family”: husband, wife, two daughters, and a dog. They said: “Welcome to our home!”, but this “welcome” wasn’t as warm and sincere as the one in the Village. Later, I understood that I wasn’t really part of that family—I would have to either adapt or leave.

I strove to adapt, faking a smile and trying to fit my opinions into their expectations—from choosing a TV show to deciding the dog’s name—even so, at the end of the day, my opinion didn’t matter at all. As someone who can’t keep my mouth shut for more than ten minutes, I felt like a part of me was dying by being constantly silenced. I was losing my essence, my identity—I had to leave.

In my second foster family I heard: “Welcome to our home!”; this family was a little more receptive and gave me time to adapt. However, my sexuality became a problem. One day, my aunt used my younger cousin to offend me, saying he would be a “man,” implying that I wouldn’t. I was shamed for being gay. Eventually, they threw me out.

I began to live by myself in an apartment shared with workmates. For the first time, I didn’t have anyone to say “Welcome” to me: I was welcomed by life. This time I didn’t have to adapt to someone else’s rules—I could create my own. But I still felt watched, surrounded and forced to follow old rules.

Real freedom only came once I moved again. For the first time, I was leaving my country and doing something because I wanted to—moving was finally a choice. I was welcomed by the unknown. I felt unsteady and shaky in the midst of that new world.

At Watson Institute, I felt as welcomed as in the Village. There, people had that same willingness as Auntie Goreth—they wanted to know me for who I was. Different from the foster system—in which people wanted me to fit into their expectations—at Watson, I was constantly invited to share my perspectives. In the first week, all

scholars had to go to the middle of a circle and tell their story. I was nervous to talk in front of people I barely knew in a language that is not my mother tongue. When my time came, I questioned if they would listen to me. But, at the end, I realized I was in a safe place—being gay and speaking my mind was not deemed as a problem anymore. I was finally allowed to voice my feelings.

The meaning of “welcome” morphed every time I moved to each of the different places I lived in, and so did certain parts of myself—I learned not to create nor try to meet expectations. By doing so, I finally felt welcomed. Not because of anyone, but because I know I can shape my future and make it a welcoming place to fit my perspectives, my desires, and embrace the changes to come. I don't need to hide who I am in fear anymore. Just as Auntie Goreth wholeheartedly welcomed me once, I welcome myself.



March 15 is a date imprinted in my memory- the day 51 innocent people were killed, one mile from my home because they were Muslim.

A stream of heartbreak, hurt and horror filled the air as our city locked down. I was in disbelief, driven by my lack of education on the people in my community. Before this day, New Zealand's darkest day, the term massacre was absent from my mind. The mosque I jogged past almost every day was a place so foreign to me. My only exposure to religion was wrapped in the chapel I attended once a week as insisted by my school. Before I could showcase acceptance and diversity to the 700 women at my school as Head Girl, I needed to grow beyond my natural bubble and step foot into someone else's story.

Bordering the first anniversary, I brought together Muslim victims and student-leaders from across the city, to Al Noor Mosque. I held onto the hope that Shahd, the one Muslim student at my school, would feel as though she had a whole army of people behind her, curious to learn about her religion because it is special. Inside this mosque where children, women and men were mercilessly gunned down, we took part in Islamic prayer together whether we were Muslim or non-Muslim. I spoke to a man called Farid. Farid's wife was shot and killed as she attempted to salvage her brothers and sisters. Farid sat peacefully in a wheelchair, not as a result of the Islamophobic attack, but after being hit by a drunk driver. The first words he spoke contradicted all the menace he had faced during his lifetime: "Forgiveness". "Forgiveness towards my wife's killer was not something I needed to think about, it came immediately. He was a victim too by having hate in his heart". I attempted to hide my watery eyes behind the hijab that hugged my crown.

After March 15, I learned the real value of people, especially those outside of my instinctive circle. I answered the question that always sits at the forefront of my mind- "What is the most important thing in my life?" He tangata, he tangata, he tangata. It is people, it is people, it is people. I realised that we are all people with stories to tell. We live in a world that is the home of every king and queen, every hero and coward, and every Muslim and Christian. We must abandon the questions of reputation and riches, and start seeking knowledge about what's actually important- people's stories. I am a person with a story. We all are.

It is quite obvious I wouldn't be here today without my parents, nevertheless, they are at the roots of my story, interests and dreams. At the age of 10, I would recite my father's emails aloud as he struggled to read beyond the words 'you', 'at' and 'I'. Dad left school at fifteen with the ambition to fuel the world and become one of the most promising farming stories in New Zealand. At his success, I grew up surrounded by potatoes, carrots, and herds of cows. The motto 'paddock to plate' was far too close for comfort as I harvested potatoes from dawn to dusk, then visited McDonald's the next day eating the spuds from my home. My exposure to the agricultural, business world is my story.

March 15, holds the worst act of terror seen on New Zealand soil, yet it made me grow. It forced me to be proud of my story and sparked my passion for sharing other people's stories through documentaries called 'Humans of Rangi'. Shown to the entire school fortnightly, students share their different cultures, upbringings and passions. Through these gems, our community has grown a sense of understanding among others. As the applause roars across the chapel after each new story is told, I feel fulfilled.



As the sun incessantly falls beyond the horizon, so too does my inner world fall into turmoil. The transformation of the blue sky into glossy pinks and oranges signals an impending battle under the darkness of the night. Since I was young, I have been terrified of the dark—of the loneliness, the irrationality, and the uncontrollable fears that would jump out in the silence. If I was the last one awake, no one would hear me if I called.

It was 2018, in Washington, DC, and I was 8000 miles away from home. As the only religious Jew at the Global Young Leaders Conference, my parents had organised for me to stay with a Chabad family in Brooklyn over Shabbat. Needless to say, I was terrified; on the plane, I stared into the deep blue day sky, wishing for its permanence.

After the flight and short taxi ride, I stood nervously on the doorstep of a narrow house. The warm, wide-smiling face of a mother opened the door, and I was greeted with the scent of challah, a white-clothed Shabbat table, and the familiar tune of Hebrew song.

This was a Jewish home just like mine, yet that evening in the shower, I cried so hard. I would never make it through the night. The anxiety bustled into my head, the thoughts waiting at a platform, boarding the train as soon as I closed my eyes. I told myself that I was being irrational, yet still I felt alone in the world, with these feelings and fears that I couldn't control. I desperately wanted to be with my family, my two dogs, and my laughing brother—with safety, certainty, and familiarity. The tears and water droplets were indistinguishable as they ran down my face.

When my hosts called me to dinner, my heart beat in my chest as I faced a sea of strange faces. But soon, the Shabbat songs, the light of the candles, and the smells of chicken soup instilled in me a comfort I had not expected to find so far from home. These simple traditions brought with them a time of quiet reflection, a recentering of self and a refocus on what's important.

As a young girl I was taught about the power of Jewish peoplehood, the power of Jewish continuity. But it was then that I truly felt I was a part of something greater than myself, a larger story that extended across borders. Here I was, singing the same Hebrew songs that I had sung just a week prior at the tip of South Africa in my own home. Traditions pave the way as footprints of a longer history. I stood here, centuries after the destruction of the First and Second Temples, Spanish Inquisition and just decades after the Holocaust. We had made it through all of that; I could make it through another night. It was like looking up at the stars and realizing that you exist for just a moment in the infiniteness of time. Strangely, it was in this insignificance that I found strength. I was a single letter in a single word in a book of a billion pages.

That night was the same as many others, my mind running, my heart aching. But it was also the night I realised that I was setting a precedent for my narrative.

As I listened to the divorce struggles of a Russian mother, argued with an Israeli millennial about the future of the Jewish diaspora, and stayed up eating Rice Krispie treats with a 34-year-old New York health expert, I realised this was a gifted moment to prove to myself: I could face and overcome my fear of the dark, of uncertainty, of solitude, just as my predecessors had done before.

There were people awake on the other side of the world. Eventually, I fell asleep.



I distinctly remember the many pairs of twitching eyebrows, tapping fingers, and the exaggerated sighs of my classmates while we had a discussion about the use of nuclear energy in Japan. Although not intended to be a debate, whenever someone spoke, they were immediately interrupted by someone who disagreed with them. We failed to separate our feelings from facts, and by the end of class, I was frustrated by our inability to communicate.

When I was 8 years old, the Great East Japan Earthquake caused one of the most devastating nuclear power plant accidents in history in the region of Fukushima. Since then, rather than cooperating to solve the energy problem, people have been engaged in an endless debate about the benefits and dangers of nuclear power.

In my classroom, the reason for the miscommunication was people being set on their beliefs. As a high school student, I have no control over policy making or research, but I am a part of the conversation, so I searched for a way to converse with as many people as possible. I spent days thinking, and then remembered my love for watching movies. I had always wanted to make my own, but I had never found a compelling story to tell. I looked at my camera that was sitting on my shelf and decided that it was time to make a documentary.

Initially, I believed that I could objectively portray the problem from both sides. I eagerly sent out emails and phone calls to scientists, companies, and government officials, and each interview felt almost like a science experiment. I asked everyone the same set of questions, and I was excited to be collecting so much data with sound reasoning.

However, this strategy started to crumble when I first visited the city of Namie in Fukushima. I tried to simply record the radiation levels and get an understanding of the policies that had been implemented there, but once I heard the stories of locals living in the city, it did not feel right to ignore their perspectives just for the sake of an objective portrayal.

I was guided by a man who had lived there all his life until the accident. He told me his memories of banquets under the cherry-blossom trees, dancing under the red lantern lights in summer festivals, and eating the first bowl of rice that he harvested. Through his eyes, behind the silent and empty city, I was able to see a city similar to mine; I was able to connect with Namie.

For a long time, I focused on positioning myself as another expert on this issue. Not being able to find a clear answer on the subject made me uncomfortable. I felt that I had to be an expert to have the authority to make a documentary, but I was an ordinary citizen. My experience in Namie showed me that although objectivity is what helps you get unbiased information, subjectivity is what brings out the humanity in what you see. I realized the best way to connect with the audience was to show my personal struggle in picking a side.

During my first screening at a film festival, I was nervous because the documentary did not present any answers. To my surprise, many people came up and thanked me after the screening for my honest portrayal of nuclear energy, telling me that watching the film made them reconsider their beliefs. My documentary ends with the words "We have not lost hope even though we have come far from finding a choice. Our investigation has just begun." By showing my own perspective, I was able to sit beside the audience, and together, we could think about the future of our country.



“What's your pain like today?”

Asked our librarian, Ms. Courtney. She looked strong in front of the books lining the wall behind her, her stature enhanced by stories of tragedy, resilience, and love. She handed me a chocolate protein shake laced with sodium and vitamins, knowing that the chocolate was the only way I could choke down the required medication to ease my symptoms of Postural Orthostatic Tachycardia Syndrome. I braced myself against the back of the wheelchair, and shrugged in response to her question, not wanting to give the full answer. Nevertheless, Ms. Courtney's smile radiated her compassion and eased some of my pain.

Her compassion also helped me see that (even in the midst of hardship) there is beauty. For instance, I remember sitting with my friend on a curb at a festival listening to the joyous laughter of children and watching their faces light up as they climbed a bouncy castle. A woman then came and sat in front of us, using sign language to communicate with her son as he raced towards the castle. The fluidity in which her fingers articulated each sign amazed me. I knew some basic signs so I approached her, and she explained (through sign language) that she was deaf and could only interact with the world around her with signs and lip-reading. As we sat together, I realized that she could not hear the music or her son's laughter. Nevertheless, her eyes were beautifully framed by smile lines. From her, I learned that language in all forms has the capacity to bring beauty to an otherwise broken world.

And I have seen beauty in the cruelest of places.

I witnessed my uncle survive a 99% chance of death from necrotizing fasciitis in his neck, even after the surgeons had given up on him. Although he was in constant pain from his medication, he found humor in an otherwise humorless situation. Some days, I can still hear him call me “Sunny” with a slurred smile and a guttural laugh created by the one vocal cord he had left. I cannot help but smile each time I get into a car as the memory of us driving fast, singing at the top of our lungs lingers with me still. After he recovered, he refused rehab and drowned himself in alcohol until his organs shut down, while the dog we had adopted together lay at his feet. Now, every sunny day, I choose to remember his strength and his resilience but also I remain aware everyone has their own demons and pain.

The next chapter of my life hangs dauntingly and daringly before me. Our world is unstable—politically, economically, and environmentally. Clear communication is the greatest weapon that we possess against the darkest evils prevalent in today's world. And for this reason, I want to continue to learn and educate myself. For me, International Affairs seems to be the best path for me to help drive out some of these evils. In any situation, I've learned that change starts with listening. To be a better

listener, our first step is learning the language of those we wish to help, be it a foreign language or local vernacular. Therefore I see myself expanding my knowledge of various languages in order to better support others.

In the end, I want to be in a place where I can enact real change in the United Nations and create a more beautiful world for those plagued by evil.

“How is your pain today?”

I am still in pain. But it's not the gut-wrenching physical pain that the librarian was referring to. Instead, I am pained like the hundreds of heroes behind Ms. Courtney, each fighting in their own story. There are thousands of stories in this small library—and even more across the globe—so many of them tell a tale of beauty and compassion and their triumph over pain.



Passover is always a crowded holiday at our house. The day before our week-long celebration of freedom begins, our kitchen is filled with three generations of women, blasting 80's hits, and the smell of onions. My mom always reminds me to wait before putting trays hot from the oven onto the counter because "remember when I accidentally made the glass tray filled with farfel explode?". I laugh and form sticky dough into kneidlach for the chicken soup.

For as long as I can remember, I've helped prepare this exact meal: the charoset, the farfel, and the kneidlach. Until I was tall enough, I stood on a step stool, carefully following the recipes that my great-great-grandparents, in their East European shtetls, passed down to me, in my family's São Paulo apartment. I read the family cookbook's instructions over and over, making sure that I was doing everything exactly right. I measured out ingredients, chopped vegetables, set timers for the oven slowly and attentively. I felt it was my duty to carry out these tasks, precisely, identically. But with time, this routine became repetitive, mechanical, mundane. Those old songs rang in my ears; I sighed as I cut up yet another carrot; I dragged my feet to set up the table. I started to tire of doing the same things over and over, year after year.

Naturally, however, as the years passed, I realized: Repetition is not an exercise in vain. Repetition yields small but meaningful growth, personal touches become traditions in and of themselves.

Every year, I'd added my own touches to the holiday's proceedings. I'd incorporated customary ingredients—leeks, potatoes, and bitter herbs—into new dishes. I'd changed the positions of the wine glasses to prevent spilling. These were simple changes, but, slowly, they became important parts of our seder. I followed the same rules and traditions, but the dishes grew more complex, and the tablecloth, thankfully, cleaner.

Later on, it's time for seder. We gather around the plastic tables set up in our jam-packed living room and begin telling the story of our people. Most of the seder is scripted, but we recount it with fervor, as if the story were new to tell and hear every year. In some ways, it is. Though we sit through hours and hours of storytelling and praying, we always find new ways to build on our traditions. We turn old Hebrew melodies into Brazilian funk songs. We scatter the table with masks, stickers, and drawings that represent different parts of the narrative of Passover. We allow our experiences from each year to expand the way we look at the story already heard so many times.

This is what really makes Passover and tradition so special. Each year, we create new meanings, memories, and ideas. We retell the same stories—stories that are repeated across generations and across the world—only to find there is more to uncover.

It is from repetition that novelty emerges. Acknowledging the past's connection to the present opens us up to possibility, innovation, and insight. Through preparing the same meals, I came up with new recipes. Through telling the same stories, we found new angles of interpretation. And I can see this, now, in everything else that might have otherwise become tiresome. I repeat the same knit and purl stitches to make a new sweater. I replicate the same procedures in the lab daily to get valid results regarding plant growth. I play the same scales with students in my music program until they have dominance over the guitar. Yes, repetition can, at times, seem pointless and annoying, but when I think of sitting with the same people, around the same table, and to the sound of the same songs on Passover, it fills me with excitement for the new things that come out of our seder every year.



As I threw open the pool's thick metal doors, the pungent aroma of chlorine swaddled me like a wet blanket around a shivering newborn. The scent was pervasive during my year-long stint on the swimming and diving team, when the fame I'd imagined for myself as a freshman remained just out of reach. As I stepped along the slimy pool deck, I brought my focus back to the reason I had revived my failed athletic career.

Gustavo Torres and I met through my school's Best Buddies Club, which connects students with and without developmental disabilities. The students' excitement as they jumped up to greet me every morning drew me into a community that made their own happiness in a world that often met them with judgment. But while Gustavo's limited mobility and reliance on a communication device made conversation challenging, these were small setbacks compared to the fact that he seemed to want nothing to do with me. We made bracelets, holiday cards, paper mache flowers, and decorated cookies, but these encounters lasted mere minutes before he'd gesture for his aide to retrieve him.

I had nearly given up on our friendship when a teacher suggested we participate in a scuba dive organized for our school's students with disabilities. At first, all I could imagine were the new ways in which Gustavo would be able to ignore me in another location - the pool.

Growing up less than a mile from Lake Michigan, I've always been attracted to the water. The first time I swam, pushing the soft water back and forth between my hands and feeling self-assurance I never experienced on land, I felt I'd touched freedom. I was liberated from being the only gay kid in a small elementary school, from constantly being made to fit into a mold when it came to my sexuality and beliefs. Everywhere I ventured, my peers insisted they knew aspects of me I hadn't explored myself. Their constant questioning of my identity - commenting on my favorite floral sweatshirt as I walked down the hallway and describing my love for classical music as "feminine" - occupied an enormous space in my brain at a time when I should have been finding answers for myself. Those brief moments of underwater clarity helped me retreat from all the boxes the world set out for me, washing away everyone's expectations like a tide smoothing out the sand when it crashes onto the beach. Every time I left the water, I felt a piece of my identity had solidified.

So perhaps I shouldn't have been surprised by what Gustavo experienced in his first swim. As his aide and I unstrapped him from the wheelchair where he spent the majority of his days, bits of food and old pieces of paper from past art projects fell to the ground. Terror filled Gustavo's eyes as the security of his chair was stripped away, but the warm embrace of the water flowing around his limbs immediately calmed him as we gently lowered him into the pool. For a brief moment, his eyes locked onto mine and we shared our excitement.

Though it was fleeting, our glance taught me an invaluable lesson. Until that point, I hadn't tried to connect with Gustavo on anything but a superficial level. Our art projects were motivated by sincerity, but they offered no channel for Gustavo and I to share something we mutually loved. Letting his fingers glide along the water's surface, I helped him float for the next thirty minutes in an uninterrupted state of bliss that can only be experienced by someone who has been confined for so long - a feeling I was able to understand. By sharing something that helped me come to terms with my identity, I was able to connect with him on a deeper level, one where we both felt free.



In a discreet wooden box lay my memories as Polaroids captured by my dad. Unlike most, our eyes don't serve as the ultimate testament to our experiences because my dad and I suffer from congenital nystagmus, a condition of involuntary and uncontrollable eye movement that distorts vision. We therefore rely on his Polaroid Sun 600 to capture and stabilize our memories. In other words, Polaroid pictures symbolize long-term memories stored for later access. Today, these tangible recollections preserve my authenticity and reveal snapshots of my personal development.

The back of Photograph 1 reads: "Andrea gets her first pair of glasses (08/13/2007)." I sit in the ophthalmologist's office, subtly announcing my resignation by gazing at the floor. A month before, I had begun using an odd pair of rectangular magenta glasses that drew attention to my eyes, making my involuntary and repetitive eye movements more noticeable. Afraid of being questioned about my condition, I avoided eye contact and failed to ask for accommodations at school. Unwittingly, I became an introvert, yet to discover the value of adaptability.

Photograph 2 is labeled: "Dad runs the New York marathon (11/03/2013)." I stand beside my dad, who seems elated while he holds his medal with both hands. I can recall how he strenuously thrust forward as he was approaching the finish line. This was the first time that I saw movement as a positive force. As an 11-year-old, I started to embrace my condition by comparing my dad's graceful movements while running to the movement of my eyes. As a result, I began sitting in the front of every class, requesting adapted materials, and candidly telling my classmates about my condition. By the time I was 13, I had consecutively been chosen as a class representative and had a variety of friend groups. Nystagmus no longer defined me because I began to develop an adaptive mindset that empowered me to openly face uncertainty.

The caption of Photograph 3 reads: "Mexico Earthquake (9/21/2017)." I am loading emergency food and water supplies into a cargo van for disaster-affected families. Two days earlier, a 7.1 magnitude earthquake hit Mexico, opening my eyes to our broken health system and deficient policy response. However, the earthquake also allowed me to witness Mexico's adaptive reaction to severe adversity and encouraged me to found Yodoc, a nonprofit organization. Through Yodoc, I seek to empower Mexican youth and prepare them to drive social change by exposing them to STEM and healthcare. Having embraced my nystagmus and seen the potential of an adaptive mindset, I believe that Mexican youth need to be resourceful and emotionally intuitive in order to face our country's uncertain future.

Nystagmus has fueled my process of self-discovery by forcing me to adapt to my environment. My growing self-assurance is evident: I used to avoid eye contact, but I now treasure the opportunity to interact with others and thrive in a myriad of social settings. Uncertainty is now a sign of confidence because I have embraced all aspects of my identity. I owe the existence of this archive of personal development to my dad and his Polaroid Sun 600. However, in college, I will begin to capture my memories through my own lens. I am eager to see where I will take the first Polaroid and where that memory will take me.



It was the penultimate day of my school's annual trip to Gambia – a trip in which we visit our partner school, Kotu Senior Secondary School, for a week to aid the improvement of the school's resources for pupils. A football match between Colfe's School and the very best footballers from Kotu was about to take place. I expected a well-kept grass field, but as I reached it I immediately realised how mistaken I was. It was indeed a field, although there was sand instead of grass and a ditch, roughly half a foot deep, ran diagonally across. I envisioned it would be easy to get to know the Kotu pupils through verbal conversation, yet this turned out to be more challenging than expected. By the end of my stay, I realised that verbal conversation is not always a necessity; there are alternatives that I can utilise to bond with others.

Throughout the week, I felt I was unable to connect to the Kotu students. The language barrier did contribute to this issue: the students had little knowledge about English, and I knew even less about French or other local tongue. However, I think my narrow-minded approach to conversing by over-relying on words was at greater fault. I was too focused on making simple conversation, which was proving to be unsuccessful when trying to learn more about the Kotu pupils to find a common ground on which we could relate. Because of this, I spent too little attention on finding alternatives to communicate, like pictures.

For the first time, Colfe's won the annual Kotu vs Colfe's football match. On top of the monumental victory, I took something else from the match. Playing with the Kotu boys offered a physical alternative to conversation. In contrast to prior conversation, where there was disparity in language, everyone was an equal on the playing field. Language had no bearing on the result of the football match. For the first time all week, it felt as if they were friends of mine because of the parallel it portrayed of friendly competition with my friends in London. Additionally, the miss-kicks on goal, I blamed the 'uneven surface' for mine, created laughter on both sides, further reinforcing the sense of growing friendship. Having this equality in communication is important because of the opportunity it presents to create strong bonds with others that cannot be made in an environment of asymmetric communication.

This insight into communication proved useful. When I moved schools last year, I only knew a few people at my new school. The idea of making conversation was scary, as I had become so familiar with the schoolchildren at my prior school that was 30 minutes closer to home. I organised a small meet-up to play football with the few people I knew, and they brought some of their friends that I had not met yet. With the common enjoyment of football, conversation flowed freely. We talked about football managers and what professional players we thought would do the best in the upcoming season. Eventually this broke off into more general conversation about school classes and teachers. Without the prior experience with physical

communication in Gambia I would have had to revert back to an over-reliance on words to develop a relationship with my new classmates – something I know I would have been less confident with in comparison to playing football.

Following the match with Kotu I sat under a tree, the shade providing refuge from the scorching Gambian sun. My T-shirt was sticking to my back with sweat, but I knew I would look back on this experience with keen fondness. As a cricket bowler, I remind myself that there are sometimes alternatives to verbal conversation when this seems ineffective. Overall, this has given me more confidence to meet new people, and I am looking forward to getting to know my fellow undergraduates.



Cheese Dumplings

Whenever I eat ravioli, pierogi, or any other dumplings, I'm amazed by the variety of tastes wrapped inside that thin layer of dough. In my culture, dumplings—or jiaozi—aren't merely about flavor. They are the core of Chinese tradition, and the absolute star of the Spring Festival feast.

In my junior year, my 82-year-old grandma flew to America to celebrate the Spring Festival with us. I begged my mom for the last few medallions of dough and made my own filling: pork, cabbage, mushrooms, and one more secret ingredient.

Against my mother's protest, I added American cheese in the dumpling filling.

What went in the dumplings was more than just cheese. It was three years of replacing chopsticks with forks, replacing qipaos with skinny jeans and sandals, replacing timid smiles with hugs and screams when greeting mere acquaintances. After coming to the U.S., I abandoned my old preferences and tried to negate my past fourteen years in China. My alteration, however, alienated me from my family: while my parents listened to Chinese classics in the car, I put on headphones and listened to Taylor Swift; while they flipped through Chinese TV dramas in one room, I watched *Game of Thrones* in another. Once, when someone complimented me on my language ability, my parents thanked them with heavy accents and sighed: "See? Only young people can assimilate into a new culture. We're too old for that." I, too, thought a stark line separated us. Our paths diverged; I was on the road toward Americanization, while my parents stubbornly persisted in their native culture.

However, I didn't want my beloved jiaozi to follow my parents' path. These dumplings deserved the same transformation that I went through, and the cheese filling was a perfect example.

On the night of the feast, dumpling soup was served. My cheese dumplings did not go unnoticed: my father's face twisted, my mom put down her spoon.

Then it was Grandma's turn.

"Aiyoo, why is this dumpling stinky? My dear, was this filling unrefrigerated for too long?"

Afterwards, everybody burst into laughter while I sat there with a weak smile. My mom sprung to the kitchen to boil more “normal” dumplings. But my grandma stopped her: “No, no! It’s Joy’s* new invention. Maybe I’ll learn to like it if I eat more!” She bit into another one. “Mmm, not bad!”

I was speechless. How could an 82-year-old woman molded by conservative Chinese society be so receptive to my “Americanized” jiaozi? Did she accept them out of love? No—my parents loved me no less. Perhaps it was her age and life experiences that rendered her tolerant of any novelty.

I wondered: perhaps the Great Wall separating me from my elders was not impassible. After my grandma proved that age didn’t prevent assimilation and a generation gap wasn’t inevitable, I tried harder to bridge this gap within my family, and I noticed that, as a result, my parents reciprocated. They encouraged me to volunteer at the town hall for the presidential election although they were apolitical. My father watched the Super Bowl and happily bought a Boston Red Sox T-shirt. My mother learned to roast turkey for Thanksgiving and asked me to walk her through their tax returns.

To first-generation immigrants like myself, cultural exchange is like cooking: you don’t have to abandon one ingredient for another; instead, every chef can blend any ingredients in different ratios to create distinct flavors. My flavor had more cheese than my parents’, but both are delicious in their own way. I no longer hide the Chinese part of me, or perceive my Americanization as a trade-off for sacrificing family relationships. Instead, I am proud of being at the intersection of two distinct cultures. Now, with my family reminding me of my roots, I am more confident to explore other cultures, and to add new ingredients to my jiaozi.

*student’s name has been changed at their request



I whizzed down the uneven road, wobbling on my yellow bicycle before careening over a ficus root. My grandfather was teaching me to ride a Brazilian Caloi, my first bike. On Fridays, he would pick me up at school and we would enjoy a lunch of fried eggs, red rice, and fresh jabuticaba—Brazilian cherries. After a siesta, we'd spend the rest of the day learning how to ride my Caloi at Ibirapuera Park.

My grandpa didn't believe in training wheels. I learned to ride by practicing among the holes and ancient tree roots in the asphalt. He would give me a strong shove, helping me find the bike's equilibrium point. Despite falling often and repeatedly applying burning iodine to my bruised knees, seeing my own progress—and my grandpa's pride—was what mattered most. Those shoves helped me grow comfortable with taking risks from a young age.

When I could finally stay up, my grandpa and I began to take longer rides in Ibirapuera. I raced him on the bike paths, as he shared stories of his childhood heroes, describing professional cyclists who passed through his village in Italy during the Giro d'Italia. As we passed Oscar Niemeyer's modernist buildings in the park, I asked my grandpa—himself a brilliant civil engineer—to teach me the physics that kept the edifices upright. He described how engineering, like learning how to ride a bike, requires continuously iterating: "If you stop trying and taking action, you'll lose balance and fall." These experiences piqued my curiosity about engineering and turned biking into a lifestyle.

During my cycling geek peak, I interned at a bike shop in my hometown. While selling bikes and accessories, I noticed how customers sought cycling as a means for sustainable living. Yet, ironically, the shop only sold metal bikes, which use non-renewable resources and end up in landfills. Provoked by the apparent contradiction that cycling's foundation wasn't truly sustainable, I asked the shop's owner why he only sold those bikes. "Of what else could they be built?", he replied. Perhaps this question was rhetorical, but I kept trying to come up with an answer.

Back in Ibirapuera Park, riding through a hundred-meter-long bamboo tunnel, I was fascinated by how the bamboo stalks waved with both strength and flexibility. I realized I could craft an equilibrium between the environment and material development. Those stalks represented the innovative path to manufacturing a vehicle that corresponded to cycling's call for sustainable living. I became determined to build a bike out of bamboo. After sketching bamboo frames in my notebook, I began prototyping and quickly learned that building a bamboo bike was easier said than done. In a few weeks, my attempted iterations had all spectacularly failed. The broken prototypes, however, reminded me of my grandpa's analogy between engineering and learning how to bike—if I persisted in creating new iterations, I would eventually succeed.

After studying how to treat bamboo with natural resin and fibers for durability, my plans started to mature. I built my first frame, handlebar, fork, and spokes. But how could I convince people to adopt such an unusual bicycle? The answer lied in commercialization through entrepreneurship. I could only convince people to use a bamboo bike if I guaranteed that it solved a specific need. Commuters wanted to charge their electronics when going to work, so I crafted a phone-charging attachment after discussing the technology with engineers. What at first seemed like a unique, one-time prototype became a real-world product with a clear value proposition.

Reflecting back, those Friday afternoons with my grandpa taught me how to take initiative, persist, and use creativity to solve problems. I hope to apply my experiences by devising and commercializing innovative solutions to my country's urban mobility and energy issues. My grandfather's lessons have inspired me to help build a future in which humanity strikes a balance between technological advances and a sustainable relationship with the planet.



My parents, like many others, sheltered me from the world as if something bad was going to happen otherwise. I believed that Singaporeans were all treated fairly and that others were taken care of. That was until June 2018, when one of my lecturers invited me to volunteer with her to deliver food to homebound elderly in the community. I would usually peer into the homes of the elderly, calling out to them. Most times, my heart sank. The elderly were usually skinny and only had just enough meat to cover their bones. This is not how we should be treating the people who built our country. I thought it would get easier each time I volunteered. It did not.

Everytime they thanked me, I heard my heart crack. We should be taking better care of the elderly in our community. All these issues were present while I was growing up, but I did not notice it at all. After a month, I realised things in Singapore were not as rosy as I thought and I was angry. How could my parents hide these issues from me? I had a rude awakening and was propelled into a whole new Singapore, exposed to the harsh realities of the world.

In March of 2020, the Ministry of Health enlisted the help of the Singapore Armed Forces for contact tracing purposes, and I was called to duty. Most of our calls were to migrant workers staying in dormitories. I, along with the Nation, quickly learned that due to their deplorable living conditions, these people were more susceptible to the virus. They had been living this way just to earn a meagre amount of money to support their families in a distant country. This was a human rights issue that I could not turn a blind eye to too.

I started small, by donating a sum of money to causes that mattered to me: food insecurity and migrant worker rights. Was I doing enough? I also started posting links to donate on my social media and asking my friends to donate some money to the beneficiaries. The people around me started to become more aware of these issues and were posting articles to raise awareness of some of the issues I was trying to get people to talk about. That was when I began to see the impact I had as an individual.

At first, it was hard, having to constantly think about other people. I was used to being selfish, only thinking about myself. But because of the experiences I got from volunteering, it got easier and it became a normal thing to do so. What was not normal was allowing these people to suffer, while someone like me, who has the privilege of living comfortably, not do anything about it. This year was a tough year for everyone. Dealing with news about deaths and crises is never easy. However, through this experience, I learned that people need to use their privilege and their voice to effect change. Just because something does not impact me does not mean that I can't be a vessel for change.

I still have this bugging feeling inside me that I am not doing enough. Therefore, I want to explore how I can use my craft to affect change and bring about positive experiences for those less fortunate than me. I believe that films are one of the ways we can spread messages. I want to make use of my experiences and stories to create films that inspire others to act as well. I recognize that the world has endless issues and inequalities and I won't be able to end it. But I can at least have an impact in my own community. I want to bring about change in the next community I will be inhabiting, be it in University or the City I live in next.



When I experienced the deaths of two patients in one night while shadowing at Waikato Hospital in New Zealand, I found myself deeply affected by the fragility of human life. This confirmed my ambition to study medicine, combining my passion for the care and treatment of others with my fascination for human physiology.

During my work experience, the importance of a strong doctor-patient relationship was exemplified by an auscultation of a patient by the cardiologist. This intimate contact showed the trust that patients have in the medical profession. Doctors build this initial trust into a strong rapport, enabling better communication with patients and encouraging patient adherence. This can lead to better health outcomes for patients and reduces stress on health systems by freeing up more resources. Observing Phase I clinical trials exposed me to the rigours of clinical research. To maintain the validity of trials, procedures that deviated from strict protocols had to be reported, demanding honesty and integrity in doctors. Upon witnessing the success of the taking of bloods under time constraints, I learnt that seamless teamwork and efficiency are required in a medical setting.

To expand my knowledge of primary care, I volunteered at a retirement home before the Covid-19 lockdown started. Being more conscious of the unique requirements of this vulnerable population, I became aware that a broad range of skills are required to treat patients of different ages. The spreading smiles on the faces of the residents during activities I hosted filled me with a deep sense of contentment. This made me think about the importance of the psychosocial wellbeing of patients and how I would try to treat patients holistically. Completing the BSMS Virtual Work Experience illustrated to me the value of using compassionate language to break bad news effectively but sensitively to palliative care patients. I realised that, to do this successfully in an intense atmosphere, practitioners need to be able to empathise and to connect emotionally.

Reading 'Trust Me I'm A Junior Doctor' by Max Pemberton and 'In Stitches' by Nick Edwards, showed me that, as a doctor, I might face long hours under intense pressure in an unpredictable environment. Wanting to learn more about cancer biology and drug development, I have completed online courses. These show that with limited early stage detection of cancer and its treatments in the face of an aging population, the burden of cancer is growing. To improve global health, I believe more extensive research into immunotherapy and personalised medicine is crucial, thanks to their reduced side effect profiles in comparison with current treatments like chemotherapy, which have extensive systemic effects.

To further explore biomedical science, I taught myself across a range of areas to achieve Silver in the New Zealand Biology Olympiad. I developed my ability to synthesise different areas of study, vital when considering the different systems of the body together in medicine. My interest in how melatonin affects the health and wellbeing of shift workers led me to do the Cambridge International Project. Through intensive research followed by independent analysis and linkage of the information gathered, I have improved my critical analysis ability.

As Deputy Head Girl of my school, I have developed my leadership skills and self-confidence by proactively engaging in events and training days, while tutoring younger pupils has advanced my teaching abilities and interpersonal skills. My history of success in academic competitions illustrates that I can deliver strong performances under pressure and it has prepared me well for the professional challenges of a medical career. I understand the realities of my choice, and as an independent learner I am motivated to become a well-rounded practitioner. Inspired to positively change the lives of others, I am committed to a lifelong journey in medicine and clinical research.



At the age of 10, my sister and I opened a restaurant in our building's lobby. As our neighbors came by, I would persuade them to buy the delicious yet overpriced dish I had prepared. Since then, I realized that business is constantly present in my life, and my passion for this area has grown exponentially. At university, I plan to build a strong academic base in management and unite it with my endless drive to solve the world's adversities.

In the spirit of impacting our planet, in 2020, I participated in a highly selective Bootcamp at IE University, where I explored sustainability from an economic perspective. I turned what I learned into reality by creating "Food 4 Good," an initiative that fights food waste while helping unprivileged entrepreneurs and local charities. It enhances the customer's desire to support local businesses by indirectly serving society and saving money. To polish my idea, I applied to the Stanford Rebuild program for social impact during the COVID crisis. The platform connected me with astounding entrepreneurs worldwide, deepened my intellect on startup development, and provided me with crucial strategic planning insights.

Moreover, I took a step further and dove into online courses about Microeconomics (UPENN) and Financial Markets (Yale); with that knowledge, I was able to potentialize the impact of "Food 4 Good." My deep passion for those subjects allowed me to observe entrepreneurial trends while studying AP World History. I scrutinized ancient trade routes and their relationship with the globalized world we have nowadays. Furthermore, in MUN, I saw the evolution of those markets in our fully integrated society and mediated debates about the global imbalances in African nations as a chair for the Economic and Social Council. My curiosity drove me to the economic impacts of Ramadan in Muslim-majority economies. According to the National Bureau of Economic Research, productivity is decreased due to the fasting and religious habits; controversially, despite the significant GDP drop during this time, those who join the holy month practices claim that their happiness rates increases exponentially. I find such tensions between cultural tradition and economic theory fascinating, and I hope to learn more about how these debates impact the world of business while studying at university.

My desire to explore the beautiful nuances of culture in business started at the Latin American Leadership Academy. Along with young leaders from all over the continent with the most distinctive backgrounds, I dove deeper into the world of social entrepreneurship, which combined my desire for social change with my eagerness to innovate. I later coached a Bootcamp in Mexico City, where I was responsible for managing the activities and leading the group throughout the week. When COVID locked us in, I gave lectures about my networking experiences. I knew I couldn't stop there, so I created events to educate prospective LALA students about fundraising

and financial aid opportunities. I also became an official Ambassador of the NGO, and I mastered my negotiation skills while representing my country within the LALA network seeking to develop partnerships with prestigious companies and sponsors.

Through my experience in different fields of business, as well as interests in the international aspects of society, I have developed a well-rounded, knowledgeable, and determined work ethic which would be put to very good use at university. By developing academic abilities in business and management, I hope that I will equip myself with the tools for a career that generates global social impact.



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It is widely accepted that the long road to integration for an immigrant begins with the learning of a language. This was illustrated to me first-hand in 2019 when I worked alongside an immigrant family as they set up a grocery shop in France. I supported them by translating product information and by facilitating communication with their clients. The gratitude offered by the family in return for my assistance highlighted the struggles of immigrant life for those unfamiliar with the native language.

Alongside direct communication, I believe literature is a vital ingredient for combating exclusion, and has been for centuries. I saw this in 'Candide', which for a modern audience is reminiscent of current migratory landscapes through the descriptions of those fleeing war and slavery. The more contemporary novel 'Le Petit Terroriste' and the film 'La Haine' have illuminated how even immigrants who know the host language are often forced to the periphery of society. This highlighted to me that like communication, intercultural understanding is a two-way process. Consequently, I was inspired to learn Syrian-Arabic through the charity NaTakallam with a refugee teacher based in Jordan, whose experiences are comparable to those of the narrator in 'Le Petit Terroriste.' These shocking insights into immigrant life prompted me to explore France's mentality towards diverse religious identities in my EPQ, and to complete the French government course 'Ensemble en France' to understand what exists to facilitate successful integration.

I believe that cultural understanding is further deepened by literature, when it allows insight into the history of a country and its inhabitants. Hearing Isabel Allende's account of her exile from Chile at a recent book launch exemplified the value of understanding the backgrounds of newcomers. 'Más Allá del Invierno' and 'De Amor de Sombra', both echo her experience, and have allowed me to develop increased empathy for those fleeing dictatorships, as I delved into their everyday struggles such as disappearances, poverty and gang violence. Lorca's 'La Casa de Bernarda Alba' and Esquivel's 'Como Agua para Chocolate' also allude to struggles under dictatorial rule. Critics, such as Bergen, have drawn parallels between Bernarda and Franco in Lorca's play, as she denies her daughters' basic freedoms and consequently, I have made similar comparisons between Mamá Elena and the dictator Diaz in Esquivel's work.

My essay for the Newnham College Cambridge competition, in which I placed second, allowed me to explore Lorca's work through a different lens alongside the works of Verne, Maupassant, Camus, and Neruda, considering the role that literature plays in the context of today's climate crisis. I argued that it is only through effective intercultural communication, often through literature, that the global climate crisis can be tackled, since the awareness of an individual's status as a global citizen, which this provides, is essential for worldwide change, be that ecological or through increased tolerance.

If we are to enable better comprehension of other cultures and backgrounds, no matter how culturally or geographically isolated, online resources have never been more valuable. I have translated 22 texts between French, Spanish and English for Pratham Books, who provide children with free access to foreign literature. I have also created a blog entitled Studentpolyglot.com in which I discuss literature, film, culture, language and linguistics with a broad audience. In doing so, I contribute to the growing body of resources, widening access to foreign culture and literature.

In an increasingly multicultural society, the ability to communicate, empathise and acknowledge foreign heritage is critical. My studies have demonstrated to me that this is best achieved through language and literature. It is for this reason that I look forward to developing my interest in these areas at university.

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Touring Yosemite with my family, I was fascinated by the wildlife it enclosed; I saw it as a contained system, removed from the 'urban' world I was used to. Yet, what I now admire about our environment are not isolated ecosystems, as I did then, but a more complete picture of the relationships between humans and their biogeographical context, understanding there is no such thing as 'pristine' nature. Taking an interdisciplinary systems approach within geography will help me address global issues by considering more than just 'human' factors.

During an expedition to Ecuador, I was able to explore this human-nature connection on a larger scale, trekking through the Amazon. I witnessed the value of its services for a range of stakeholders including raw material provision and GHG mitigation, noting its vulnerability to increasing exploitation by capitalist 'winners'. Reflecting on Yosemite, I feel as though sometimes in contemporary views, conserving certain areas 'justifies' exploiting others. This complex relationship highlights the need to understand coupled systems; deforestation is more than the environmental impact of an economic activity, as for some Indigenous communities it represents a loss of culture and way of life.

While in Ecuador, I helped build a school for a rural village. I am keen to tackle real-world problems, particularly those regarding inequity, and believe education is fundamental in this mission. My interest in improving access to education for young children fuels my work as a volunteer teacher at the Czech School Without Borders (CWSB) charity, delivering language, history, and geography lessons. With my values of diversity shaped by my Czech-American background, in teaching, I focus on conserving cultural identity, as conservation ideas should not just apply to National Parks and reserves. Motivated by my experiences in Ecuador and desire to address the loss of cultural heritage as a real world problem, on a smaller scale, I help Czech children engage with wider world views while maintaining cultural traditions, by creating a library app, and starting a Czech music club.

Becoming more familiar with members of the Czech diaspora, I have gained an insight into the contemporary problems they face: a fleeting sense of place and belonging with growing insecurity and discrimination. This, catalysed by Brexit, increased the disparity between Czech residents' and emigrants' customs. In the context of greater geopolitical issues and the current Covid-19 pandemic, migration patterns and mobility networks have been rapidly evolving, compelling me to study how external factors affect Czech citizens' movement from the UK. These ideas were refined during professor Heaven Crawley's lecture at the RGS with her theory that migration crises are rooted in wider socioeconomic inequality, inspiring me to help marginalised communities. Guided by an RGS spreadsheets course, I synthesised a model using my own data and wider research, helping the CSWB predict resource allocation and teacher hire, improving economic efficacy to ensure the school can continue aiding the cultural development of its pupils.

During the Ecuador fieldwork and my research, I interacted with diverse groups of people, which I continue to do, competing in international water polo (representing England), singing in a multi-school choir, and playing an active part in the CWSB for 11 years. These commitments have honed my time management skills and instigated leadership qualities and resilience under pressure.

Crucially, these activities have exposed me to many perspectives, key to successfully tackling geographic challenges. I know geography's commitment to helping others and its integration of human and physical interactions can address issues, such as environmentally threatened livelihoods, migration perceptions, and cultural heritage loss. I hope to apply this commitment to reducing inequity, while pursuing community-based international development.



In Year 9 I visited the 'City of Arts and Sciences' complex, which precipitated my interest in science. I learned about the ALMA observatory and its research on comets, and was fascinated by how spectroscopy is used to find the chemical composition of the comets so far away and deduce structural information, which inspired me to pursue a career in Physics

Apart from my A Level subjects, I study Mathematics and Physics from the Spanish curriculum, which cover additional topics such as relativity and orbit dynamics. This allowed me to expand my knowledge beyond my A Levels and the steep learning curve provided an enjoyable challenge. I especially enjoyed learning about atomic spectra and their uniqueness to each element; I had always wondered how the chemical composition of faraway objects like the Sun were known. Taking more subjects taught me how to perform well consistently, thrive under pressure, and manage my time well.

I read '15 Million Degrees' to learn about the sun. I particularly enjoyed reading about the path of a photon from the Sun's core to the outside world; realising how far the photons travel in each layer during the journey gave me a deeper appreciation of the complex structure of a star. It also gave me more insight into the importance of chemistry in astrophysics and to further explore this interdisciplinary link I read 'The Cosmic-Chemical Bond'. A chapter that stood out to me was on the planet formation process from both a physical and chemical perspective. It gave me a deeper understanding of planet formation and the role of ionisation in determining whether it leads to a rocky or 'ice' planet. This surprised me as I always thought charge is only significant for small processes on a molecular level, not impacting large processes on the length scale of planets. I came to realise the complexity of the universe is almost beyond comprehension and this motivates me to learn more.

I took the 'An Introduction to Astronomy' online course by the University of Cambridge. I found this course very enlightening, especially the unit on exoplanets and the essential conditions required to support life. Having found out about the discovery of amino acids on the surface of comets, I read an article from *Astrobiology Magazine* about their role in forming life, which excited me, as it presented the possibility that similar events may have taken place across the universe.

My interest in planets led me to take part in projects COSMIC and Planet Four 2.0 where I identified swiss cheese terrain and vents on the surface of Mars. It was rewarding to take part in an active research project and gain experience in sorting scientific data. As the quality of the images often made classification difficult, I became more confident in my observation skills. I was able to experience both the exciting yet sometimes tedious nature of research and it taught me how to deal with the surprisingly large number of setbacks researchers face daily.

My experience made me realise the crucial role data analysis plays in scientific research and how coding is integral to solving complex problems. As a result I started learning Python and was surprised by how many steps are involved in fulfilling a simple command.

It is important to me to make science more accessible. As I play the violin, I am coordinating a fundraising concert to give girls in Ghana access to education. I also organise science webinars for children as an intern at the Kashmir World Foundation, where I teach topics like thermodynamics and ocean currents. Simplifying complicated concepts has made me understand them better.

The opportunity to improve on current knowledge and contribute to future discoveries excites me, fueling my aspiration to undertake research that may help to understand the universe in all its complexities.



My deep connection with language began when I moved to the UK aged eight, speaking no English. To survive, I quickly had to acquire it, learning Spanish and French later. The fact that English was the easiest of the three to pick up made me wonder whether it was because of constant exposure, or because I acquired it within a critical period. In my school's Linguistics club, I started a discussion about when this period ends. Varying perspectives arose from the experiences of those bilingual students who had always handled two languages and those who, like me, had acquired one in their late childhood. We agreed that the critical period plays a key role in second language acquisition. Through this debate, I discovered a curiosity for academic discussion related to language.

Deciding to explore multilingualism further, I read "The Psycholinguistics of Bilingualism". Its take on code-switching gave me a new perspective on an instance in which I used the English word "awkward" in a conversation in Spanish because it could not be translated directly. While I had initially thought that code-switching was a malfunction of the brain, I now recognise that it can be an important social advantage in multilingual communication, as it allows for more precise expression of thought.

I furthered my understanding of the reasons for such cognitive effects by working on a personal project titled "To what extent is being bilingual advantageous?" I critically examined and compared existing research and data in order to form my own analysis. Although I had anticipated that the mental agility provided by bilingualism contributes to abilities like selective attention, it amazed me that the cognitive advantage goes so far as to delay brain disorders.

I have shared my thoughts with other enthusiasts on my Linguistics blog, which provides an excellent opportunity to reflect on what I have read. For example, I recently wrote about a discovery that I made while reading "Invitation to Linguistics": the fact that computers cannot fully learn language due to their lack of human qualities like empathy. I expanded on this point to talk about how astounding it is that humans, by contrast, are hardwired to learn language without any theoretical knowledge.

Noticing that Cypriot Greek is less similar than mainland Greek dialects to Russian—my mother tongue—while solving an Olympiad problem led me to develop an interest in the effect of differences in dialect on comprehension. I have studied a Norwegian play in English Literature, the translations of its title being "A Doll's House" and "A Doll House" in British and American English respectively. It has intrigued me to think that to an American speaker the presence of a possessive in the British version may imply a sense of ownership. I have come to the conclusion that the smallest changes in language can affect perception.



I enjoy comparing languages as much as I do dialects. Inspired by structural comparisons between Romance languages in “The Wonders of Language”, I chose to examine European languages more closely. My Mathematics IA project used statistics to evaluate the demographic, economic and educational factors affecting second language acquisition in 27 countries. This broad perspective provided great insight, and, as I had expected, foreign language teaching in schools is a very important factor, since it initiates and consolidates second language acquisition.

My experience of using rhetoric as a Debating Captain has reinforced my ability to persuade. I have gained confidence in my leadership skills watching younger girls that I have trained develop the same ability. I have also set up a Spanish debating competition at school, the highlight of which has been looking at Spain through the eyes of Spaniards while being immersed in the language.

I look forward to using both scientific and humanities-based skills at university to investigate language in all its complexity.



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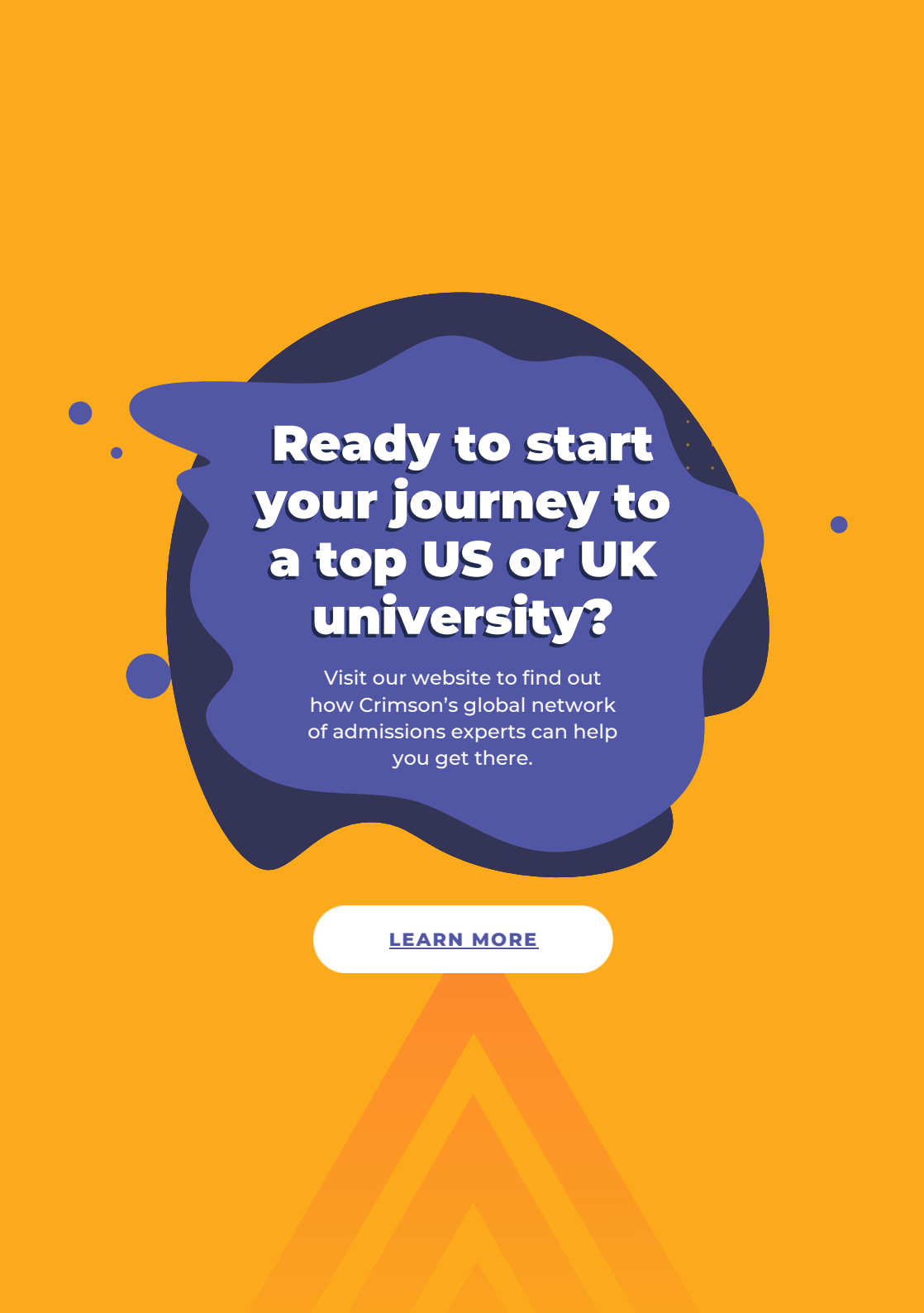
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